

Officer Santana

"... recent power surges have knocked out heating elements in zones 23, 42, and 71. Expect lows in the 3 to 5°C range and ..."

A cold day was the final straw for Valentina Santana this morning, as she slams the snooze button on her clock radio. Looking around her bed, she sees her husband has inadvertently stolen the covers last night as he recovers from a bout of the flu. Chilled to her chitin, Santana sighs and throws her legs over the side of the bed. Taking a moment to get her head to equilibrium and rubbing her claws together to warm them up, she walks over to the window unit and presses the button to draw open the shades.

The primary star of the system, Saavgh, with its pleasant velvet hue peaks out from the bottom of the window. Santana gently lets herself start day dreaming, wondering what it must be like doing the engineering on the thrusters of the space station that create the gravity, and induce day and night cycles that would otherwise be inaccessible planetside due to tidal locking. The size of the project always boggled her mind, a ring around the planet. It seemed so wasteful when you had the whole planet right there. But when the rich and powerful want day and night and the ability to watch over you, quite literally, they get what they want. And if that wasn't enough, the court system for the local quadrant was placed in the ring, an incredible political spending campaign that made the brazen corruption in the war-torn galactic outposts look like child's play.

Santana sighs. The days of her political activism and protesting are squarely behind her. Even without her kids, she just couldn't muster up the energy to leave the house after work if she didn't have to. Reaching over to the dresser, she grabs her netpad and checks her calendar for the day. A sensory overload of rivaling sports practices, tutoring sessions, and a recital consumed the lionshare of her Saturday. But in the morning after breakfast, the dreaded pink reminder. Maintenance, radioactive iodine. Ugh. Nausea, fatigue, and a chill she knew wouldn't leave her the whole day. No shower long enough to prepare her body for the multitude of football games sitting on the ice-cold bleachers.

Not letting that stop her, Santana heads to the bathroom and turns the shower on to the max temperature she is willing to take without feeling like a cooked lobster. As she waits for it to heat up, the alarm clock wakes up from the snooze and galaxy ring radio begins to fill the quiet space.

"... the district attorney's office has continued to ramp up the crack down on fraud in quadrant 927's UBI program. Expert witnesses from around the galaxy are being flown in to testify..."

Santana rushes over to turn off the clock before it wakes up her husband or god forbid the kids. These precious minutes she has in the mornings have been the only thing keeping her going the last few months and whatever bullshit the DA was doing she would care about during work, not on her day off. Heading back to the bathroom, she gets into the shower and enjoys the luxurious 5 minutes of her shower ration before the water shuts off. She realizes with disappointment that she forgot to close the door to the bathroom, so all of the glorious steam has escaped into the bedroom and she is left trying to quickly wrap a towel around herself before the chill starts to set in.

She looks at herself in the mirror. Taking a long moment to appreciate the reflection she sees is a version of her mom without any of the scars of war. She may have her own scars but they were inside of her. Outwardly, she tries to project the strong mom her three kids needed. The mom that seemed invincible. Even if she has/had cancer. Even if grandma and grandpa have untreatable dementia. Well treatable but her family can't afford that and her kids don't need to know that yet. Better let them live a bit of life without the boot of the universe on their neck. The cold, dark bearing down...

Santana shakes herself. She knows she can't fall down that rabbit hole. Not now. Not today. Not for her kids. She tells herself that day is soon but not now. Maybe when Carlos kicks his cold and gets a job. When she didn't have to choose between paying rent, utilities, or elderly care this month. Maybe when she could have a full portion of dinner rather than splitting with Carlos so the kids could have full portions. Maybe when fucking Universal Basic Income meant what it said. So yeah, maybe one day. But not today.

One leg and then the next and the next, etc, she gets into a pair of leggings that she thrifted a few weeks back when the kids were with Carlos. She admires how the colors and design give her a facade of warmth and fun she doesn't feel. She carefully selects a cute top to match and risks a glance at the clock. 16 more minutes until she needed to wake the kids.

Moving with as much stealth as she could muster, Santana makes her way out of her bedroom into the hallway and past the kids room without so much as a single floor tile squeaking. In disbelief, she jokingly pats herself on the back and as if god hadn't done enough recently, Pinky starts barking as Santana enters the kitchen. Without missing a beat, she grabs the jar on the counter and in one fluid motion throws a treat through the dog door near the back of the house. In a jolt, Pinky flies through the dog door and out into the back. Her heart beating rapidly, she strains to listen for the sounds of the kids stirring. Thankfully she doesn't hear anything. Waiting for her heart to slow down, she focuses on her breathing, trying to bring it under control. Slowly she manages to calm down and she mentally notes to talk to her doctor about the sensitivity about her heart.

"Okay I promise to go to services tomorrow, I get it." she says as she moves her claws through the habitual prayers she performed since she was a little girl. She scans the room looking for her prayer beads, finding them buried under half eaten sandwiches and last month's unfinished math homework. Grasping the beads in one claw, and a piece of a sandwich in another she sits at the counter. One by one she moves through the beads, with each one silently repeating the litanies that get her through the day, the ones her mom taught her, the ones she teaches her kids.

Abruptly shoving the sandwich chunk into her mouth, she stands up and begins preparing the various lunch boxes, snacks, and drinks her kids would need for the day. 13 minutes later she comes back to reality after the absolute zone she was in. The kitchen in shambles, peanut butter, apple seeds, and tang powder covering her apron, Santana quickly pours herself a cup of coffee from the pot and sits down to enjoy her last few minutes to herself. The bitter acidic brew hits the back of her tastebuds and she feels as ready as she can be.

One leg in front of the next, she goes over to the door of the kids room and knocks loudly.

"Kids breakfast is ready. Get dressed for your football games and Sabina don't forget to choose your outfit for the piano recital later. If you don't pick something out, I will bring the yellow dress you hate."

And there it was. The yelling. The sounds of pillows being slammed into faces. The cacophony of three siblings fighting their way to cogent. Even with the way the day was going, Santana couldn't help but smile and appreciate the fun her kids were having. From what she was hearing from her friends, in a few years they will be ignoring each other, listening to their favorite songs on the nets, pretending like they don't share a 10 meters squared bedroom. For now, it worked. For now the sounds of playful laughter could be heard on the other side of the door and that was enough.

The next half or so was a total blur. Like she did every day, somehow she got everyone fed, clothed, and ready for the day. Carlos made an appearance, blowing kisses through the air before shambling back into bed to

continue to sleep off the cold. Santana made another mental note to pick up his presubscription when she was at the pharmacy after her appointment. She took a deep breath.

"Kids, mommy needs to get her medicine again this morning. Since daddy is sick you have to come with me to the hospital. Antonio can you grab crayons and the coloring books? We should only be there 1 hour before we head out to the football games."

The briefest moment of tension is felt across the room. The kids for what seems like microseconds, pause their reenactment of a trending vid on the net, look at their mom and take her in. Santana unconsciously responding to the moment, pincers her leggings causing the passive chemicals to respond and change the colors in a complex diffusion. Not a sigh to be heard, but a familiar ritual overcome, the kids immediately go back to snapping at each other. Santana takes a long breath and just beams at her kids, their resilience in all of this and their trust in her. As she grabs the keys for the apartment and puts on her heavy coat, the kids snap to attention and run over to her like a scene out of an ocean biology vid. Santana looked over her three kids, making sure they had the right coats on, their bags, the meals, the dress for the piano recital, and, and...

A moment of panic starts to creep up her mind. She can't remember the important thing she had to bring. She takes a quick breath, makes a mental note to talk to her doctor about memory problems and starts to scan the room. Toys all over the place, juice spilled, cereal thrown about, nothing out of the ordinary, except the craft supplies were all over the ground. Ah. Santana looks over at Antonio's bag and can see the crayons and coloring books crammed inside, making the bag burst at its seams. She giggles to herself silently and ruffles Antonio's antenna playfully. Antonio, not understanding what is going on, just smiles at his mom and kicks his brother in one of his legs.

"Okay kids let's go. We are going to take the tube to the clinic, it shouldn't take more than 20 minutes to walk to the station and another 45min tube ride. If you guys behave on the walk over, I will treat each of you to one candy of your choice at the station, if you behave on the tube, we can go out for pizza after football practice."

In a flash, the once rumbunctious siblings transform into tiny soldiers; yes ma'am, no ma'am, may I pee ma'am. Once upon a time in a universe without cancer, Santana was nonplussed with the soldier act, but she learned long ago to not look a gift horse in the mouth cause it might have cancer and no one needs more cancer in their life. She chuckles to herself as they march to the station, to any outside individual looking at her family they must look crazy.

At the station, the perfect soldier facade starts to crumble as Hugo spots his favorite candy bar and Sabina, not wanting to be outmatched for her brother, steps out in front to be the first to lay claim to the prize. Santana is about to say something but out of nowhere Antonio puts a claw on each of his siblings as whispers something to them, every once in a while looking back at her. Now less orderly than soldier mode but something more closely representing her children when they were at church, the kids select their candies and patiently wait until they leave the store to devour them. Antonio on his last bite, looks over at his mom, tacitly offering some of the candy bar to her, Santana waves him down encouraging him to finish. She takes a moment to appreciate Antonio's emotional intelligence and every way he has stepped up around his siblings since she got the diagnosis. Knowing her family would only come out stronger from this experience, fills Santana with everlasting joy and hope.

The tube ride comes and goes for her without notice. The entire time, Santana being enraptured sitting and watching her kids try to maintain their perfect soldier poses as they tried to balance against the constant starts and stops of the tube. As soon as the kids stepped off the tube, all hell broke loose. The perfect children she was just admiring, going actually primal. Biting, kicking, you name and it was happening.

"What in the hell do you think you're doing! Do you call this behaving in the tube!?! When we get home... Damnit. I said just tube ride didn't I?"

"Yes, momma" all three kids say at once.

"If you want ice cream with that pizza, you will behave until football practice."

"Any flavors?"

"Any flavors."

And with the magic words spoken, the soldiers returned. Glancing at her netpad and doing some mental math, she sighs a breath of relief, the overtime shift at the courthouse the other day meant she had a little wiggle room in the budget this month. The rest of the journey to the clinic was uneventful, Santana steeling herself for the delicate balancing act she had to perform taking her medicine and playing with her kids. First reception, the nice officer worker distracting her kids with small toys. Then the long walk through the sterile hallways, the smells of the sick and dying pervasive. She had heard rumors that the fancy clinics on the ring offered at-home visits, complete with massage and tea ceremony. All she wanted was a private room that didn't smell like her mother's retirement home. Arriving at seat 17, in a room that couldn't be more packed with patients and their families, Santana settled into the chair. Various medical instruments used to monitor vitals automatically deploy after she tapped the button on the front. Once the rhythmic sounds of her heartbeat were picked up on the monitor, the needle that starts her treatment gently enters from a slot in the back of the chair.

The treatment surging through her veins, Santana picks up a pink crayon and starts coloring the dress of a princess fighting a villainous turtle creature. The kids press up their bodies to her legs, settle in and start coloring.